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God, Master of Arts

On the Relation between Art and Religion

Abstract

What does theology have to do with art in this (post)modern period? To make clear why art and religion can be related in a positive way, the question of why art is of value will be posed (1). Subsequently some examples will be critically discussed of how art and religion have been related in theological aesthetics (2). Finally, in dialogue with the positions discussed, I will develop my own approach to theological aesthetics (3).

[1] What does theology have to do with art in this (post)modern period? Or, stated more broadly, what do art and religion have to do with each other in our time? I will show that aesthetics, as the study of the beautiful, as the philosophy or science of art (Miriam-Webster Unabridged), is also part of Christian theology.[1] Theological aesthetics is one of the disciplines through which theology finds its place in culture; more specifically, it is the field of study in which reflection on art and literature in their significance for religion, church and theology, takes place.

[2] The question of whether art and religion can be of significance to each other is sometimes answered negatively by those involved in art as well as by theologians or lay believers. As far as the field of art is concerned – in my title I use the plural because there are several arts but, for convenience's sake, I will usually use the singular – in the Netherlands, unlike in Germany, England or the United States, there is often silence with respect to religious themes in art. Joost de Wal, who researched the topic of Dutch visual art and religion from 1945–1990, writes:

> in Germany and the United States a great deal of attention is bestowed by art historians, theologians and critics on religious themes in the work of prominent contemporary artists, but that does not happen – aside from the odd exception – in the Netherlands[2]

[3] At the end of his study, de Wal concluded that

> religion [plays] a more important role in art after the war than is apparent from a renowned survey like *De Nederlandse identiteit in de kunst na 1945* (1984).

1. For the term aesthetics I refer to the following works: *The Routledge Companion to Aesthetics*, ed. B. Gaut and D. McIver Lopes (London: Routledge, 2002); *Aesthetics and the Philosophy of Art: The Analytic Tradition. An Anthology*, ed. P. Lamarque and S.H. Olsen (Oxford: Blackwell, 2004); 'Ästhetik,' in: *Theologische Realenzyklopädie* (Berlin: De Gruyter, 1977), part 1, pp. 544–72. For the term 'theological aesthetics' see R. Viladesau, *Theological Aesthetics: God in Imagination, Beauty and Art* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), ch. 1.

2. J. de Wal, *Kunst zonder kerk* (Amsterdam: Free University Press, 2002), p. 17.

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> That study, which gives a full overview of the stylistic tendencies in the period 1945-1980, skips the theme of art and religion entirely. This is not justified by the many examples of Christian art ... and the diverse references to other religions in the work of prominent painters and sculptors.[3]

[4] The refusal to discuss religious themes can also be found in the well-known American scholar, Clement Greenberg.[4] He defends a formalist theory of art: the only correct standard for judging a work of art is the form and not the content. The artist needs to use the power of the medium with which he works and to avoid the influence of other arts, such as literature. Painting is concerned with the possibilities that the canvas itself provides. In this case that is, the flatness of the canvas, its two-dimensionality, and thus Greenberg rejects the illusory depth perspective that has been used since the Renaissance. Greenberg thus argues for the purity of the art form used and rejects, moreover, the idea that the painting has content or a theme. It is clear that there is little room in this formalist and purist view for possible religious and spiritual content or the significance of a painting, even though the artist may have had this in view, given the title or accompanying commentary. Art is autonomous and one cannot pose any theological questions to it.

[5] Theology and the church also view any kind of positive connection between religion and art with suspicion. In 1948 the last *Index Librorum Prohibitorum* was published. The Holy See listed more than 6000 books as unwholesome. This approach did change with Vatican II in the 1960s. This council gave room for cultural emancipation. In *Gaudium et Spes*, one finds: "Literature and the arts are also, in their own way, of great importance to the life of the Church."[5] In recent years aesthetics has received more attention in the Catholic Church.[6] As far as Protestant theology in the Netherlands is concerned, ethical theology, with its openness for culture, has been overshadowed by the dialectical theology of Karl Barth. Did Barth's critique of liberal theology and cultural Protestantism of his teachers not throw out the baby with the bathwater? The cultural dimension of the Christian faith was badly served in the Netherlands by the Protestant churches and theology, despite the countercurrent represented by persons like G. van der Leeuw, H.R. Rookmaaker, C.W. Mönnich, Regn. Steensma, M. Barnard, and others. We call Dutch culture a culture of ministers and merchants, but, in

3. De Wal, *Kunst zonder kerk*, p. 248.

4. For what follows see: C. Greenberg, 'Towards a Newer Laocoon (1940),' in: *Pollock and After: The Critical Debate*, ed. F. Frascina (London: Routledge, 2002), pp. 60–70. C. Greenberg, 'Modernist Painting (1965),' in: *Modern Art and Modernism: A Critical Anthology*, ed. F. Frascina et al. (London: Paul Chapman, 1982), pp. 5–10.

5. Pastoral Constitution on the Church in the Modern World, *Gaudium et Spes* `http://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat{}-ii_cons_19651207_gaudium{}-et{}-spes_en.html`.

6. S. van Erp, *The Art of Theology. Hans Urs von Balthasar's Theological Aesthetics and the Foudations of Faith* (Leuven: Peeters, 2004); R. van den Brandt, 'Twintigste-eeuwse literatuur: een uitdaging voor theologen. Verkenningen voor een interdisciplinair gesprek,' in: *De theologie uitgedaagd. Spreken over God binnen het wetenschapsbedrijf*, ed. R van den Brandt and Rob Plum (Zoetermeer: Meinema, 1999), pp. 35–60.

fact, theology is scarcely a serious dialogue partner in the public sphere, let alone that of art.

[6] The situation sketched above is the context in which the question arises as to why a theologian would accept a chair of aesthetics. I would like to throw a different light on the relationship between art and religion. This relationship can be discussed from different points of view – from that of art or from religion. I will discuss it from the perspective of religion, specifically, from that of the Christian religion. I will gradually indicate a more specific formulation of the problem. To make clear why art and religion can be related in a positive way, I will first pose the question of why art is of value. I will see if there is a basis on which art and religion can meet each other. If such a basis can be found, I will subsequently give some examples of how art and religion have been related in theological aesthetics. It will become apparent that these examples are problematic. For that reason I will, finally, show how I myself want to approach theological aesthetics.

1 Why is Art of Value?

[7] Why is art of value? David Hume and Immanuel Kant see the value of art in that its gives pleasure.[7] A painting, a poem or piece of music is good if it gives pleasure. Pleasure can, however, be caused by very different things. Art as entertainment may contribute to a pleasurable evening, whereas a play by Beckett can provide intellectual pleasure. Many things in life that we do not consider to be art, such as sports or a holiday, give us pleasure. That is why the quality of giving pleasure is not enough to distinguish the pleasure that art gives from the pleasure that other things give Kant thus attempts to define the pleasure that art gives more specifically as the pleasure that arises from the beauty provided by works of art. He describes the beautiful as 'disinterested' pleasure.[8] We do not look at the apples that Cézanne painted in order to appease our hunger. Rather, the disinterested viewing of Cézanne's still life with apples concerns its beauty, through which we experience pleasure.

[8] Does the value of art consist in *beauty*? Who is not impressed by the statues of the Greek sculptor Praxiteles, Giotto's frescoes in the Scrovegni chapel in Padua or Raphael's portrait of a young woman? There are, however, different objections to seeing beauty as the central value of art. First, the sources of beauty can be very different from one another and not limited to art—such as a sunset, an animal or human being with a fine form, or stylishly designed kitchenware. Moreover, what is beauty? In Plato's dialogue on beauty, Socrates asks Hippias: "just teach me satisfactorily what the absolute beautiful is, and try in replying to speak as accurately as possible."[9] It is difficult to meet that request. There are views of beauty that describe beauty precisely as harmony or the proportionate

7. D. Hume, 'Of the Standard of Taste,' in: D. Hume, *Essays Moral, Political and Literary*; I. Kant, *Critique of Judgement*.

8. Kant, *Critique of Judgement*, part 1, § 2.

9. Plato, *Hippias Major*, 286d-e, transl. Benjamin Jowett; `http://www.ellopos.net/elpenor/greek{}-texts/ancient{}-greece/plato/plato{}-hippias{}-major.asp`.

relation between the parts or beauty as lustre or sheen. However, the question of the definition beauty is answered differently, depending on time, place and culture.[10] The diversity of views on beauty cannot be decided by taking one understanding as normative. How problematic it is to see beauty as characteristic of art is demonstrated by the fact that in some periods of the history of art and some schools of art did not see beauty at all as the decisive characteristic. In oral cultures, art and life constitute a unity and the question of the aesthetic value of an object is not an issue. There, art has a religious function and the images of the gods are even better if they are ugly instead of beautiful.[11] If one listens to the atonal music of Arnold Schönberg, then some, such as me, will be fascinated by it. But I do not thereby immediately exclaim 'How beautiful!' Has 'beauty not burned its face' by the violence of the two World Wars? The *Guernica* of Picasso is an impressive painting, but few would call this symbolization of the violence of the Second World War beautiful. The avant-garde art of the 20th century challenged the traditional views of beauty as harmonious forms. Art is not about beauty but about seeing the world with different eyes: archaic, cubist, surrealistic, or a presentation of everyday objects in unexpected contexts. Moreover, the 'ugly' is also a part of the aesthetic experience.[12]

[9] Others attempt to locate the value of art not in beauty but in influence of art on our state of mind, our *mood* and *emotion*. Aristotle pointed to how tragedy evoked the emotions of 'pity and fear' in the audience. Tragedy shows the disastrous consequences of certain acts and does that in such a way that these emotions undergo a catharsis.[13] Leo Tolstoy agrees with this and holds that art is not about beauty primarily but about love of neighbour and solidarity.[14] The strength of this view is that it emphasizes that art is a form of communication. Art has a social character. The objection to this view is that art is only about feeling and emotion. We should also not confuse art with morality.

[10] To give pleasure, beauty, expression to emotion are unmistakably important aspects of the value of art for the artist or the public, but these values do not yet explain why especially great works of art make such an impression and have such influence. In my view, one value that can explain this I have not yet mentioned, i.e. that of *providing insights*. Shakespeare's *Othello* gives us insight into jealousy; Picasso's *Guernica* depicts the alienation that the horrifying violence of war produces. Messiaens *Diptyque* translates, on the organ, the contrast between

10. This is Umberto Eco's thesis in his, *On Beauty: A History of a Western Idea* (London: Secker & Warburg, 2004).

11. G. van der Leeuw, *Wegen en Grenzen* (Amsterdam: Paris, 1948), p. 219. I refer in this article to the second, enlarged edition. The English version, *Sacred and Profane Beauty: The Holy in Art* (London: Weidenfeld and Nicolson, 1932) is a translation of the first edition. Van der Leeuw himself considered beauty as a value of great significance in the Christian religion. Von Balthasar is known as the 'theologian of beauty.'

12. M. van Nierop, 'Kitsch en andere lelijkheid,' in: *Mooie dingen. Over de esthetica van het object*, ed. M. van Nierop et al. (Meppel/Amsterdam: Boom, 1993), pp. 50–60.

13. Aristotle, *Poetics*, VI 49b24.

14. L. Tolstoy, 'What is Art?' In: *The Philosophy in Art*: *Readings Ancient and Modern*, ed. A Neill and A. Ridley (Boston: McGraw-Hill, 1995), pp. 506–22.

the earthly life and eternal life, the paradise full of happiness. These examples show that, by using the phrase providing of insights, I do not mean what has been called didactic art, in the sense in which art in the Middle Ages functioned as the Bible of the poor. In the latter, art is more of an illustration of theological insights held by the church. I am talking about a different view: art, in its own way, gives surprising or new insights. Art provides, as these examples indicate, insight in a *different* way than the sciences do. Pointing to the cited examples, *Othello* depicts jealousy differently from how psychology does; Picasso's painting depicts the violence of the bombardment of Guernica on 26 April 1937 in a different way from the historical account of it; and Messiaen's translation into sound is much different from the language found in Christian dogmatics. The difference lies in that art provides insight through imagination. Because of imagination one speaks of a figuration of reality unique to art. According to Merleau-Ponty, the painter does not imitate reality but distils what is finest from it and gives a new insight. Painting visualizes the fundamental characteristics of something and constructs its own world. "The seeing of the painter is a matter of being reborn continually."[15] Something similar happens in literature. The poem, the story or a novel evokes another world, the 'world of the text' (Ricoeur). Nelson Goodman speaks, with respect to art in general, of ways of making worlds, of versions of the world. His thesis in his *Ways of Worldmaking* is "that the arts must be taken no less seriously than the sciences as modes of discovery, creation, and enlargement of knowledge in the broad sense of advancement of the understanding."[16] Because works of art can create worlds, they refer to more than the existing world. By using the term exemplification, Goodman shows how movements of a dance, for example, do not exemplify any normal or familiar activities but have a creative function. They discover, as it were, new experiences.[17] The same can be said of a painting, of literature or of music. Art can broaden our insight with respect to our orientation in life, the ascription of meaning—according to the view of aesthetic cognitivism that I am defending here. We would have to go too far afield to work out now how the giving of insights happens in each field of, although I will later provide an example from painting.[18]

[11] With respect to this last value, the same obtains as for the other three values mentioned. This value is not necessarily found in all art. A certain work does not need to have all values, such as providing pleasure, beauty, giving expression to emotion or the giving of insights, in order to be called a work of art. Obviously, we can speak about art only in terms of family resemblances. I consider the last value, the giving of insights, to be of great importance. This is so, first of all, because this value explains why art is indispensable for society. Art provides insights into the life orientation of a culture. This provides a basis for a

15. M. Merleau-Ponty, *L'Oeil et l'Esprit* (Paris: Éditions Gallimard, 1964), p. 32.

16. N. Goodman, *Ways of Worldmaking* (Hassocks: The Harvester Press, 1978), p. 102.

17. N. Goodman, *Languages of Art: An Approach to a Theory of Symbols* (Indianapolis: The Bobbs-Merill Company, 1970), pp. 64f.

18. On this question see G. Graham, *Philosophy of the Arts: An Introduction to Aesthetics* (London: Routledge, 2005).

ground shared by both art and religion. Both art and religion are concerned with insights regarding direction in life and the ascription of meaning.

2 The Relationship between Art and Religion: Exclusivism and Inclusivism

2.1 Exclusivism: Rookmaaker and Van der Leeuw

[12] How is the relation between art and religion viewed within theological aesthetics? I will limit myself here to a few representatives of the Protestant tradition in theological aesthetics?[19] The Neo-Calvinist Hans R. Rookmaaker assumes, with Herman Dooyeweerd (both taught at the Vrije Universiteit), that creation is a richly differentiated whole, with laws given by God. Art belongs to a different sphere of which the central defining feature is beauty.[20] The task of the artist is to make something beautiful as God made the world beautiful: "God saw that it was good" (Genesis 1:9).[21] The relationship between art and (the Christian) religion is determined by the Neo-Calvinist notion of the *antithesis*, the antithesis between belief and unbelief.[22] Rookmaaker emphasized that the quality of art does not derive from the status of the artist's relation to Christian faith. Rather, it has to do with the talent of the artist to make something beautiful, "provided that he remains within the scope of the norms for art, provided that he works out of the fullness of his humanity, and does not glory in the depraved or in iniquity or glorify the devil."[23]

[13] One can raise objections to this view. The uniqueness of art is emphasized – art and beauty are distinct aspects of the world in which we live – but at the same time art is judged on the basis of the Christian faith in a way that is theologically questionable. In Neo-Calvinism God is viewed one-sidedly as the sovereign lawgiver of the creation, in which God is then afterwards active in Christ as love and grace for believers. God's being, in this view, is split between his will (God as lawgiver) on the one hand and his love (God's grace) on the other. This finds correspondence in a division in humanity: the 'covenant of works' that obtains for all humanity and 'the covenant of grace' for the elect. Creation and redemption are thus separated from each other.[24] The term 'common grace' was used with respect to the world, but the distinction between common and special grace entails the risk of not doing enough justice to the unity of God's being, his

19. For the Catholic position see R. Viladesau, *Theological Aesthetics*, and Van Erp, *The Art of Theology*. For the Orthodox position see P. Evdokimov, *The Art of the Icon: A Theology of Beauty* (Wheathampstead: Anthony Clarke, 1990).

20. H.R. Rookmaaker, 'Sketch for an Aesthetic Theory based on the Philosophy of the Cosmonomic Idea,' in: *The Complete Works of Hans R. Rookmaaker*, ed. M.Hengelaar-Rookmaaker, Part 2 (Carlisle: Piquant, 2002), pp. 24–79.

21. H.R. Rookmaaker, 'The Creative Gift,' in: *The Complete Works*, Part 3, p. 207.

22. Rookmaaker, 'The Creative Gift,' p. 147.

23. H.R. Rookmaaker, *Modern Art and the Death of a Culture* (Wheaton: Crossway Books, 1994), p. 228.

24. Thus correctly J. Begbie, *Voicing Creation's Praise: Towards a Theology of the Arts* (Edinburgh: T & T Clark, 1991), pp. 143–55.

will and love, and thus the consistency of his acts. This position is, moreover, not very fruitful with respect to art, because art is viewed very negatively from the perspective of the Christian confession. Thus Rookmaaker writes in his famous *Modern Art and the Death of a Culture*: "to look at modern art is to look at the fruit of the spirit of the avant-garde: it is they who are ahead in building a view of the world with no God, no norms."[25] Not incorrectly, G. van der Leeuw compared this view to the relationship "of the seven provinces in the time of the Republic to the Generality lands. They are also included – primarily to obey."[26]

[14] How does the phenomenologist of religion and theologian Van der Leeuw himself see the religion between art and religion in his well-known work *Wegen en Grenzen* (1948)? He distinguishes four different structures of the ways in which religion and art can be related: 1) the complete unity of both, as in 'primitive' cultures, where they still appear; 2) a structure of transference in which the connection between both is looser and finally completely external; 3) the conflict in which religion and art oppose each other as hostile entities; 4) a newly discovered unity.[27] He refers to these four structures in the areas of dance, drama, word, image, architecture and music. As a phenomenologist, he points to ways and boundaries between art and religion; as a theologian, he experiences "repeatedly the miracle of both streams of religion and art flowing together."[28] He wants to restore the unity of art and religion. Other than Rookmaaker, Van der Leeuw does not begin with God the lawgiver but with the incarnation, with God in Christ. He points out that Paul calls Christ the image of God. The Image, the fact that God imaged himself, is the centre of his theology of the arts.[29] "It should be possible – it can be possible – to recognize in human works of beauty the features of God's works, if God himself has given his earthly creation the features of his own image."[30] In itself, this is important and one can look at art in this way. Van der Leeuw goes one step further, however, and lets his view of art be determined by his apostolate theology. For Van der Leeuw, art is primarily interesting as Christianized, baptized art. For him, the relationship between art and religion is based on this notion of re-Christianizing. I will remark in passing that the times have changed and that the Christian presence in the current multireligious society should be formulated differently.[31]

[15] As a man of the political Breakthrough Movement (Doorbraakbeweging),Van der Leeuw looks at culture differently than the Neo-Calvinist Rookmaaker. Van der Leeuw rejects the idea of being closed within one's own circle and stands in the midst of culture. Despite this difference, Van der Leeuw and

25. Rookmaaker, *Modern Art*, p. 222.
26. Van der Leeuw, *Wegen en Grenzen*, p. 2.
27. Van der Leeuw, *Wegen en Grenzen*, p. 439.
28. Van der Leeuw, *Wegen en Grenzen*, p. 47.
29. Van der Leeuw, *Wegen en Grenzen*, pp. 466, 337f.
30. Van der Leeuw, *Wegen en Grenzen*, p. 471.
31. Van der Leeuw, *Wegen en Grenzen*, p. XIV. On Van der Leeuw's position see also M. Barnard, *De dans kan niet sterven: Gerardus van der Leeuw (1890–1950)* (Zoetermeer: Meinema, 2004), ch. 2.

Rookmaaker share the same position regarding the relationship between art and religion. Both see this relationship as *exclusive*: not in the sense that the Christian faith excludes art but in the sense that the Christian faith provides the norm for art. Whether the relationship between art and religion is governed by common grace and the antithesis or by re-Christianizing does not make much difference. In both cases the Christian religion determines the relationship, whereas art simply has to come on board, so to speak. Such a view is defended now by Phillip Blond, a representative of the postmodern theological movement Radical Orthodoxy.[32]

[16] With reference to method Rookmaaker and Van der Leeuw fall short of the mark because they work with a concept of religion that is too limited. They view religion as the organized Christian religion. Christian doctrine is the standard for evaluating art and culture theologically. If such a standard is used, then the relationship between religion and art can be seen only as *exclusive*, the attitude of having the whole truth without recognizing that secular art can also be enriching for the Christian faith. Art should be Christianized art. For that reason, art that is not is quickly judged in a negative fashion. In addition, both Rookmaaker and Van der Leeuw emphasize the place of beauty in art. In this view insights in art from which theology can learn are missed. Nor does theology learn from the critique of church and theology that comes from the world of art. To give an example: the figure of Jesus appears worldwide as a figure in countless novels and stories by prominent writers. Kuschel, who researched this, sees a general tendency emerging in much literature on Jesus: many writers are critical of the church but positive concerning Jesus as he appears in the gospels.[33]

2.2 Inclusivism: Tillich

[17] We seem to have reached an impasse: theology should assess art on the basis of its own 'concern,' but such an assessment often amounts to giving little room to art as an entity independent of church and theology. Paul Tillich seems to have broken through this impasse. Therefore, I will go more deeply into his theology of art.

[18] The great merit of Tillich is that he has developed a broad concept of religion in distinction from religion as organized. When he speaks of religion in connection with culture, he views religion as the involvement of the unconditional or the ultimate, in distinction from organized religion. It is in this way that we must read his well-known statement that 'religion is the soul of culture and culture the form of religion.' Each of the different areas of life refers in its own way to the ultimate and that also obtains for art. He argues for *correlation*, a mutual involvement of art and religion with each other. By means of painting

32. P. Blond, "Perception: From Modern Painting to the Vision in Christ," in: *Radical Orthodoxy*, ed. J. Millbank *et al*. (London: Routledge, 1999), pp. 220–42.

33. K-J. Kuschel, *Im Spiegel der Dichter: Mensch, Gott und Jesus in der Literatur des 20. Jahrhunderts* (Düsseldorf: Patmos, 1997), ch. 5.; K-J.Kuschel, *Jesus in der deutsch-sprachigen Gegenwartsliteratur* (Zürich/Gütersloh: Benziger Verlag/Gerd Mohn, 1978). K-J.Kuschel, *Jesus im Spiegel der Weltliteratur: Eine Jahrhundertbilanz in Texten und Einführungen* (Düsseldorf: Patmos, 1999).

and literature I will show how Tillich (and others following him) relate art and religion.

[19] What makes a painting a *religious* work of art? A work of art is not religious because it has a religious theme as its content, such as Christ or Madonna figure. It is not the content but the *style* that determines whether a painting is religious. Usually, in addition to speaking about a painting's style, we speak about its content, its themes and about the form or composition, the play of line and colour. Tillich adds to this the term *Gehalt*, by which he means the metaphysical meaning or depth of a painting. If he states that the style determines whether a painting is religious, then he does not mean style in the sense that art history means it, such as the impressionistic or expressionistic styles. He means it as a theological concept. Style points to the way in which the surface is broken open so that the ultimate can be evoked. Such a breaking of the forms can be seen clearly in the way in which Cézanne paints a still life, Van Gogh a tree or in expressionistic painters. The naturalistic realism of Frits van Uhde's *Christus in Emmaüs* is a reproduction of empirical reality and is thus the least religious because it does not break open this reality and thus lacks any metaphysical depth.[34] *Style* is "the immediate influence of depth-content (*Gehalt*) on form."[35] As a theologian, Tillich looks at paintings to see to what extent they show *Gehalt*, the metaphysical depth that evokes the ultimate. Thus he writes:

> it is indeed possible to see in a still life of Cézanne, an animal painting of Marc, a landscape of Schmidt-Rottluff, or an erotic painting of Nolde the immediate revelation of an absolute reality in the relative things; the depth-content [*Gehalt*] of the world, experienced in the artist's religious ecstasy, shines through the things; they have become 'sacred' objects.[36]

[20] The criterion for distinguishing between religious and non-religious paintings is their expressiveness: to what extent is the surface of reality broken open and are the forms such that the *Gehalt*, the metaphysical depth of reality, is evoked. Tillich borrows this criterion from art movements like expressionism and the Neue Sachlichkeit, but 'expressiveness' is not limited to these art movements.[37] Tillich points to examples of expressiveness, through which an work of art becomes a religious work of art, throughout the history of art, such as in the work of Jeroen Bosch, Pieter Breughel, Grünewald, Goya, etc. A painting to which he often returns is Picasso's *Guernica*. He calls it religious because the surface is broken open and something of the ultimate appears, in which we participate and from which we are alienated at the same time.[38] Nature in the painting is stripped of

34. P, Tillich, *The Religious Situation* (1926/1932), in: P. Tillich, *On Art and Architecture*, ed. J. and J. Dillenberger (New York: Crossroad, 1987), p. 69, cf. pp. 96, 178. Hereafter abbreviated as AA.

35. P. Tillich, *Religious Style and Religious Material in the Fine Arts* (1921), in: AA, p. 51.

36. P. Tillich, *Religious Style and Religious Material in the Fine Arts*, in: AA, p. 54.

37. P. Tillich, 'Gläubiger Realismus II (1928),' in: P. Tillich, *Gesammelte Werke*, Part 4 (Stuttgart: Evangelisches Verlagswerk, 1961), pp. 88–106, 88f.

38. P. Tillich, *Contemporary Visual Arts and the Revelatory Character of Style* (1958), in: AA, p. 136.

its empirical form. It no longer concerns content, outward factuality – the bombardment of Guernica – but the violence of war as such. Tillich calls it the most Protestant painting because it is a prophetic protest against the destructive and demonic powers of the world.[39]

[21] To what extent must we now state that the relationship between religion and art is one of *correlation*, of mutual involvement? The pole of art is not converted to the (organized) Christian religion but seems to point in its own way to the ultimate. Tillich himself learned a great deal from art for his theology and borrowed key theological concepts from art.[40] Nevertheless, as we will see, it does not truly concern a correlation between art and religion in Tillich.

[22] Tillich limited his theological analyses of art to painting and architecture. Others applied his insights to literature on the basis of Tillich's correlation method of question and answer from his *Systematic Theology* (1951). Poetry, novels, drama as well as philosophy are viewed, à la Tillich, as a reservoir full of questions about life to which theology must give the answers.[41] It seems as if a step backward has thus been taken, and art and culture are only a collection point for questions to which theology may provide answers. Does this still evidence correlation, a mutual involvement between art and religion whereby art is also recognized in its uniqueness? Primarily in Germany but also in the United States, Tillich's question and answer method has been applied to 'use' literature for theology.[42] Usually skipping any kind of analysis in accordance with literary theory, literature is used as a supply room for questions about life for theology. This is a denial of literature's value in itself and it is used simply as a collection point for questions about life, as a registry of the 'questionableness of human existence', so that theology can present its theological answers. In this approach, any correlation between art and religion is lacking because a *mutual* relationship is lacking.

[23] How far does Tillich's view of the relationship between art and religion take us? Tillich's attempt, as a theologian, to interpret art raises questions:

[24] 1. Tillich wants to indicate the ultimate, the metaphysical depth, in art. He assumes here that the ultimate *can be unambiguously construed to be the personal God of the Christian faith*. This is true of only a limited number of artists, such as composers like Messiaen, Tavener and Pärt, or painters like Van Eyck, Rembrandt, Van Gogh and Malevich. Both in philosophy as well as in art there are several ways in which the ultimate can be construed. In metaphysics, the ultimate has been described as pantheistic (Spinoza), as mind (Hegel) or as matter (Marx). In the evocation of the ultimate, Kandinsky and Mondriaan have been influenced by theosophy. And I have not yet mentioned the art that is inspired by the other great world religions, such as Hinduism, Buddhism, and Islam.

39. P. Tillich, *Existentialist Aspects of Modern Art* (1955), in: AA, p. 95, cf. AA, p. 179.

40. W. Schüssler, 'Die Bedeutung der Kunst, Kunstgeschichte und der Kunstphilosophie für die Genese des religionsphilosophischen und kulturtheologischen Denkens Paul Tillichs,' in: *P. Tillich: Kunst und Gesellschaft*, Tillich Studien, Vol. I, (Münster: Lit Verlag, 2004), pp. 49–87.

41. P. Tillich, *Systematic Theology* (London: James Nisbet, 1968), I, p. 70.

42. G. Langenhorst, *Theologie und Literatur: Ein Handbuch* (Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 2005), pp. 22–26.

[25] 2. Tillich identifies not only the ultimate with the personal God, but he also defines the style in which the religious is evoked in painting. The model for this is the way in which transcendence is evoked in expressionism, namely as the breaking open of the surface. The criterion of expressiveness is, in my view, too limited. If the *Gehalt*, the metaphysical depth, is assessed in painting in this way, then the possibility of other evocations is cut off all too quickly.

[26] 3. Taking both of the above considerations together, I conclude that, with respect to the relationship between art and religion, Tillich trades in the exclusivism of Van der Leeuw and Rookmaaker for *inclusivism.* That is to say, he does not only read in his own view of the ultimate in evocations of it but also sets the style in which the ultimate in painting must be expressed. Art outside the church that refers to the ultimate would implicitly refer to the personal God of the Christian faith.

[27] 4. In his theological assessment of paintings as to whether they have metaphysical depth, Tillich ignores the aesthetic analysis of the artwork. The theological appreciation of a work of art is thus separated from the aesthetic assessment of the art historian or art criticism. The same applies *mutatis mutandis* for literature. The question is whether the religious meaning of art can be determined without reference to art history, theory and the hermeneutics of art.

[28] 5. Tillich is concerned primarily with *pointing to the unconditional or the ultimate in art, in which content or theme is of secondary importance*. A painting is, after all, according to him, not religious because of its religious theme but because of its metaphysical depth. If Tillich looks at the content of a painting, this is limited to subjects like alienation and negativity. Let us recall that he called Picasso's *Guernica* the most Protestant painting. Whatever art has to offer in the way of insights is already placed *a priori* by him within the framework of his Lutheran theology of sin and grace.

[29] In short, Tillich's contribution to theological aesthetics is that he, because of his broad concept of religion, can appreciate art outside the church theologically. Nevertheless, there is nothing here of a correlation between religion and art in the sense of a *mutual* involvement. He trades in exclusivism for inclusivism: the ultimate in cultural expression is to be derived from the Christian faith.

[30] The views of the relationship between art and religion that I have discussed above lead me to specify my problem as follows: Is it possible to sketch the relationship between art and religion in such a way that there is a true mutuality between them that does justice to both the uniqueness of art and that of religion?

3 The Relationship between Art and Religion as Correlation

[31] The exclusivist position of Van der Leeuw and Rookmaaker comes down to a confrontation between religion and art outside the church. Tillich's inclusivist position focuses, in painting and architecture, on the implicit ultimate that is made equivalent with the God of the Christian faith and in literature on the questions of life to which theology provides the answers. The correlation does

not truly exist. The position that I will propose is that of a correlation, of a mutual involvement of art and religion in which justice is done to the uniqueness of both. I will demonstrate that in the following way.

[32] Art is, as stated, particularly valuable because it provides insights concerning orientation in life (ğ 1). Because religion also creates a life orientation both are thus concerned with the same thing. The common interest lies in a worldview that I will understand broadly as an interpretation of human existence as such. I do not therefore limit 'worldview' to an organized worldview but also include the worldview that is not as such organized, fragments of worldviews. Everyone has, in one way or another, an implicit or explicit worldview, an interpretation of human existence. For that reason I have called worldview an anthropological category.[43] I have also argued elsewhere for a broad concept of meaning and the attribution of meaning, which can be shaped in a secular, spiritual or religious way.[44]

[33] The correlation between art and religion lies in the worldview (in the broad sense of the word). If worldview, instead of a broad concept of religion, is the basis of the relationship between art and religion, then art does not have to be converted to religion as it is in the two positions described above. Also, if art is respected as art, it is of great importance for religion and, vice versa, religion is an important source for art. I emphasize that we are talking here of art outside the church. The place of art within church and liturgy is a different matter and important enough to give separate attention to it.

[34] I will mention two matters to show how art is important for religion. First of all, the way in which the ultimate is evoked in art and how this relates to theological speaking about God. In order to prevent us from reading our own theological views into the evocations of the ultimate in art, we need to analyze works of art by using the appropriate interpretative tools (methods found in art history, literary theory, musicology). Only then can the theological interpretation of art begin. Only when it has been established the way in which a painter like Friedrich or Rothko evokes religious transcendence, can the conversation with theology begin.

[35] Apart from the ultimate, there are also other themes concerning the basic interpretation that are valuable for theology. For theology, literature is important not because it deals with fundamental questions but primarily because it can provide insights that lead theology to reflect. Moreover, it expresses religious ideas like grace, reconciliation, death, etc. in a secular language and not in the (for many) incomprehensible language of theology. Shakespeare's *King Lear* concerns a king who appears to lack all wisdom. He divides his kingdom among his three daughters in a whim. Theologically, the play is interesting for the way in which death functions in it. At the end of the play Lear has his dead daughter in

43. W. Stoker, *Is Faith Rational?* A Hermeneutical-Phenomenological Accounting for Faith (Louvain: Peeters, 2004), section 3.5.1.

44. W. Stoker, *Is the Quest for Meaning the Quest for God? The Religious Ascription of Meaning in Relation to the Secular Ascription of Meaning* (Amsterdam: Rodopi, 1993).

his arms – a dramatic moment that is almost a secular *pietà*.[45] Cordelia is, after all, an example of true humanity. The old Lear recognized the love of his daughter too late and now calls, with the dead Cordelia in his arms: "Do you see this? Look on her. Look, her lips, / Look there, look there."[46] At that moment Lear himself dies. Is that really the end? In the course of the play Lear was reduced to nothing and now he is reduced to pure dust. Death is taken seriously here, but is it truly the end? The theological question here is how life comes to fulfilment. Or does life simply end with no fulfilment, as real life seems to suggest? Another example: T.S. Eliot's poem "Ash Wednesday" and Virginia Woolf's novel *To the Lighthouse* provide insight into the tension between the splintering of time and the search for an eternal moment.[47] Such insights are interesting for theology with respect to reflection on the relationship between time and eternity. There are, of course, a number of explicit religious themes that come to the fore in literature: Kuschel has shown in his studies on Jesus in literature how Christology can be enriched by taking note of this.[48]

[36] The relationship that is sketched here is one of a correlation between art and religion, in which theology is challenged by insights in art to which it will or will not respond. Some speak here of a dialogue between art and religion. That seems to me to be very desirable, but in practice scarcely anything happens on this score, as far as I know.[49] For the time being, I will say that at issue here is a broadening of the horizon of theology by art. Art interprets countless religious and worldview themes that are often left tacit. This is a task for theology and religious studies. The theologian will sometimes share insights with art and sometimes differ from it; sometimes there will also be an enrichment of the insights of the one by those of the other. We would misunderstand the situation if we held that in this relationship it is only religion that benefits. The reverse is also the case: for many artists the Christian religion is also a source of inspiration at present—which also obtains for the other world religions.[50] For that reason it seems to me that the relationship between art and religion is correctly characterized as a mutual one, based on their common interest in the interpretation of human existence.

[37] By characterizing the relationship between art and religion as correlative, I also indicated what I do not mean by the title of my lecture, God: Master of Arts. This can be interpreted to mean that God is the teacher of the arts. Such a view often means that theology determines the norm for art. I reject that, as is clear from the foregoing, and have a different interpretation. In church fathers

45. On this and what follows see P. Fiddes, *The Promised End: Eschatology in Theology and Literature* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2000), pp. 61, 66–71.

46. *King Lear*, V.iii.ll. 311–12.

47. Fiddes, *The Promised End*, ch. 5.

48. See note 33.

49. Langenhorst confirms this with respect to the relationship between theology and literature in German-speaking countries (Langenhort, *Theologie und Literatur*, pp. 214–23). For theology and literature in the English-speaking world see, in addition to note 45????, D. Jasper, *The Study of Literature and Religion* (Basingstoke and London: Macmillan, 1992) and the journal *Literature and Theology*.

50. See note 3????.

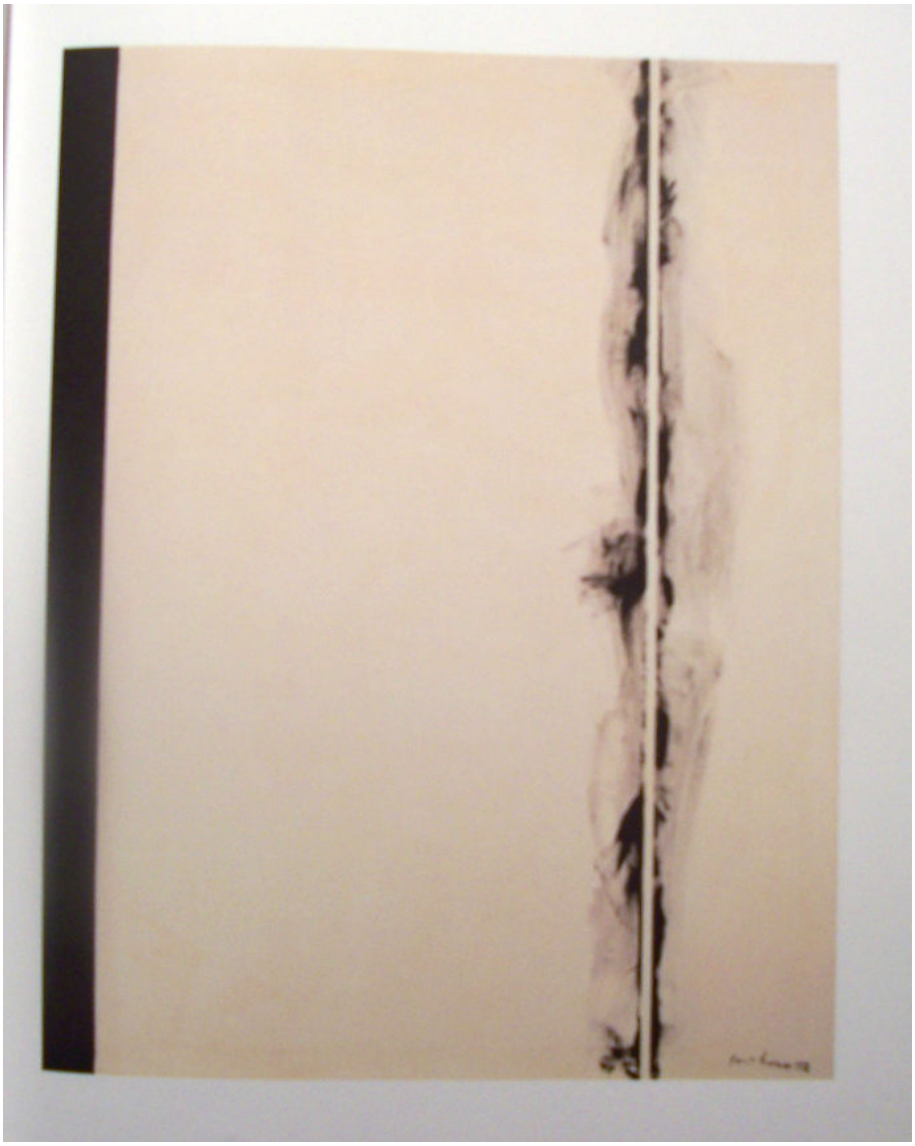


Figure 1: Barnett Newman, First Station, 1958, Magma auf Leinwand

such as Ambrose and Augustine, God is seen in his work of creation as the great artist and artists often compare their own creative process with God's work of creation. And this is not incorrect: in art something of a revelation can occur. God is, after all, involved with the whole world, and thus also with art. Indeed, God: master of arts.

[38] I will now give an example of such a theological approach to art by means of Barnett Newman's *The Stations of the Cross*. Unfortunately, there is no room to give examples from literature, for example.

4 Barnett Newman's *The Stations of the Cross*

4.1 The Work as Artwork

[39] A first look at Newman's *The Stations of the Cross* (1958–1966) can be baffling because there are so few recognizable features. The first time it was exhibited, some were shocked, especially at the title that undeniably referred to the Catholic tradition of the fourteen stations of the cross, the episodes of Christ's journey to the cross from Pilate's house to Golgotha. Others, like myself, were fascinated at the first viewing of Newman's paintings without being able to indicate directly what it was precisely that leads to such fascination. Or perhaps one is simply overcome by it, as happened to the visitor to an exhibition of *The Stations of the Cross* in Peter Handke's *Die linkshändige Frau*. Years later she tells that it was an impressive experience for her.

[40] We see paintings without frames and of a considerable size, flat surfaces without perspective. Greenberg speaks, in connection with the history of the avant garde paintings, of the refusal of the flat surface of the painting 'to make a hole' for a realistic, perspectival space, as is the case in traditional painting.[51] Cubism still has something of a flat depth because it has a certain sculptural structure. Abstract expressionism breaks this open, continuing the later work of Monet, which is characterized by a 'polyphonic' structure that arises through accentuating points and fields of colour. What Greenberg says about the work of Jean Dubuffet and Jackson Pollock obtains also for *The Stations of the Cross.* Here we see:

> . . . the all-over 'decentralized,' 'polyphonic' picture that relies on a surface knit together of identical or closely similar elements which repeat themselves without marked variation from one edge of the picture to the other.[52]

[41] The perception of paintings like *The Stations of the Cross* is direct. There is no mental reconstruction necessary to establish what we see as is the case in expressionistic or cubist paintings. We, the viewers, are not confronted with partial aspects from which we must construct a whole. The image is immediately present; we see in one glance the field and the zip (the vertical line). The use of colour is extremely sober: white and black in different hues. The zip is continually different. A major change occurs in station 7 where the broad line is now on the right side, whereas previously it was on the left. From the ninth to the eleventh and in the fourteenth station, the black is missing and the surface is entirely broken white in different tints.

[42] The style says something about the content of the paintings. The abstract in abstract expressionism alludes to the desire to create forms that through their abstraction have an intellectual content.[53] Newman calls his art 'ideographic,' by

51. C. Greenberg, 'Towards a Newer Laocoon,' p. 68.

52. C. Greenberg, 'The Crisis of the Easel Picture,' in: C. Greenberg, *Art and Culture: Critical Essays* (Boston: Beacon, 1961), p. 155.

53. B. Newman, 'The Plasmic Image (1945),' in: Barnett Newman, *Selected Writings and Interviews*, ed. J.P. O'Neill (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1992), pp. 139f. Hereafter abbreviated as BN.



Figure 2: Barnett Newman, Seventh Station, 1964, Öl auf Leinwand

which he means that they express an idea via the abstract form. He borrows this notion from Indian art. There too an abstract form is used that is directed at what Newman calls a 'metaphysical understanding.' Thus, he himself is concerned with abstract forms with an intellectual content that has to do with the mystery of life, of the human being and nature.[54]

[43] What is the content here? Let us pose a question as an aside: Who decides that actually—the artist, the painting or the viewer? In general, one should be careful with the explanation of the artist: it is the work itself in which

54. B. Newman, 'The Ideographic Picture (1947),' in: BN, p. 108.

the intention of the artist is or is not realized. The starting point for the meaning is the work of art itself in dialogue with the viewer. Where the meaning is not directly clear, as is the case here, hints by the artist can help us on our way. Even though I pay a great deal of attention to the intention of the artist, that does not affect the fact that the meaning of a work of art needs to be established in the dialogue of the viewer with the work of art.

[44] The use of colour, of black and white in different hues, points, like the title, to the content. Newman points in this context to the black, white and grey of *Guernica* with its tragic theme.[55] Newman gave his paintings the title of *The Stations of the Cross* with, as subtitle, the saying of Jesus on the cross: *Lema Sabachtani* (Why have you forsaken me?). He writes concerning this subtitle in the catalogue during the exhibition of *The Stations of the Cross* in the R. Solomon Guggenheim museum (1966):

> This is the Passion. This outcry of Jesus. Not the terrible walk up the Via Dolorosa, but the question that has no answer ... This question that has no answer has been with us so long – since Jesus – since Abraham – since Adam the original question ... The first pilgrims walked the Via Dolorosa to identify themselves with the original moment, not to reduce it to a pious legend; nor even to worship the story of one man and his agony, but to stand witness to the story of each man's agony: the agony that is single, constant unrelenting, willed – world without end.[56]

[45] It is thus not a historical, dateable event of Christ's journey to the cross, not a representation like, for example, the *Kruiswegstaties* (1946–1947) of Aad de Haas, but the representation of the suffering of the question of why. In *The Stations of the Cross* the content is the cry of the why of suffering. The size of the paintings has been chosen because the 'human scale is for the human cry,'[57] All fourteen are about the same size, two by one and a half meters (198 x 152–154 cm).

[46] Let us look at these paintings which have been called 'the Sistine chapel of the 20th century.'[58] Newman emphasizes that, because of the Second World War, content (subject matter) has become important for painting.[59] What is the content of *The Stations of the Cross*? Light and dark combine in different ways in the painted stations. The black in station five and six is strong. In station five the black dots and the prickles of energy could point to the why, whereas the zip has become a line–is that a reference to the silence of the 'other side'? Station six indicates acceptance. After the refusal of the answer in station five and six, the divine opposite in a dramatic opposite, whereas station eight seems to indicate a directionless balance.[60] In stations nine to eleven the black is missing. What

55. Newman in 'A Conversation: Barnett Newman and Thomas B. Hess (1966),' in: BN, p. 277.

56. B. Newman, 'The Stations of the Cross: *Lema Sabachthani* (1966),' in: BN, p. 188.

57. Newman, 'The Fourteen Stations of the Cross (1958–1966) (1966),' in: BN, p. 190.

58. F. Meyer, *The Stations of the Cross: Lema Sabachthani* (Düsseldorf: Richter Verlag, 2003), p. 160.

59. Newman, 'A Conversation: Barnett Newman and Thomas B. Hess,' in: BN, pp. 274f.

60. This is Meyer's (*The Stations of the Cross*, p. 140) view as well.



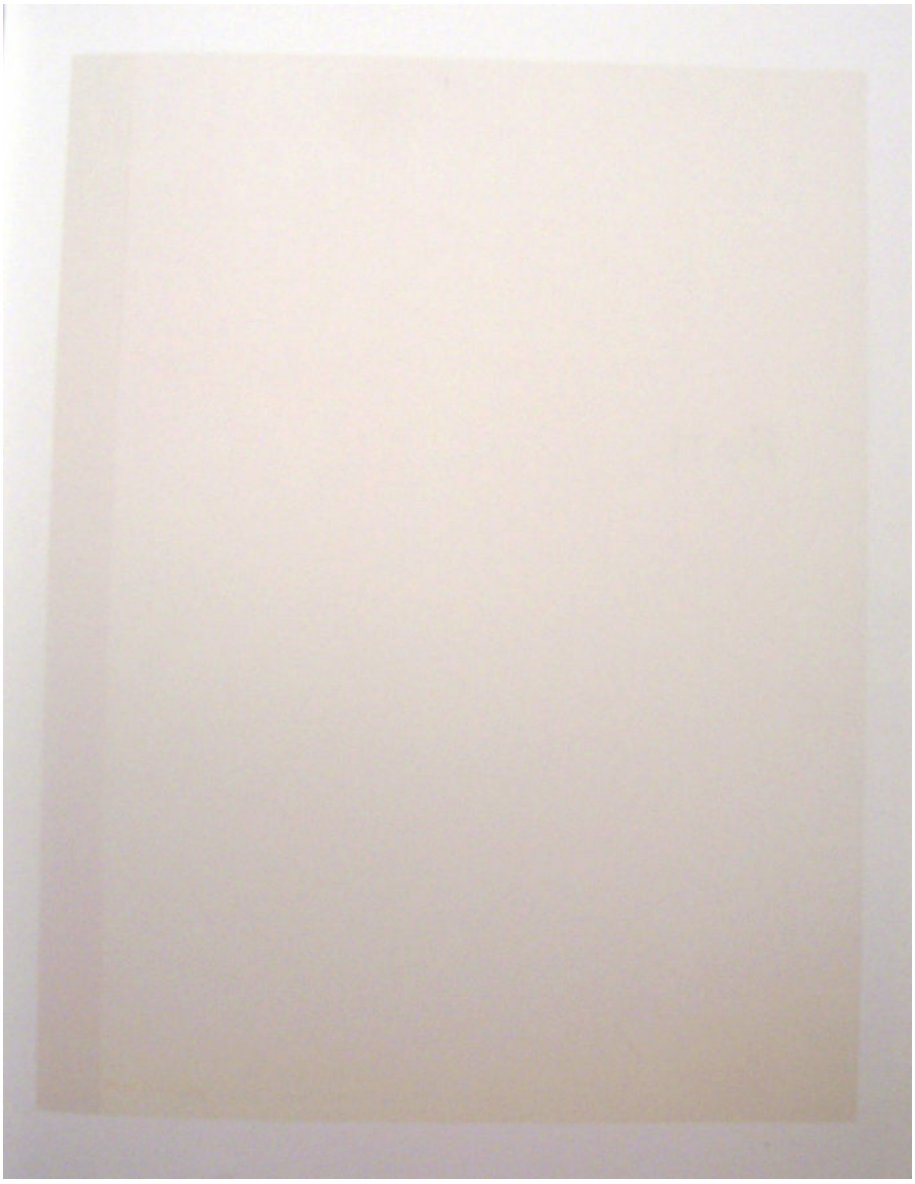
Figure 3: Barnett Newman, Fifth Station, 1962, Öl auf Leinwand

is also striking is that the fourteenth is entirely broken white with different tints. How is that to be understood? Which key must we use here for interpretation?

4.2 Hermeneutical Analysis

[47] *The Stations of the Cross* is a good example of how art provides insights with respect to orientation for human life. Newman says that the contemporary painter is concerned with the mystery of life.[61] He himself, of Jewish descent,

61. Newman, 'The Plasmic Image (1945),' in: BN, p. 140.



[48] Figure 4: Barnett Newman, Fourteenth Station, 1965–1966, Acryl und Duco auf Leinwand

often gives his paintings biblical titles like Adam, Eve, Joshua, Covenant, etc., in addition to titles from Greek mythology. Here, however, he borrows his title from the Christian tradition. As in much modern works of art that have religious themes, he breaks here with traditional iconography, in this case with the usual depiction of the stations of the cross. Two questions will concern us here: the question of a correct explanation and the question of the meaning of *The Stations of the Cross* for theology.

[49] Should we view the content of *The Stations of the Cross* on the basis of

the Jewish and Christian tradition? Looking at the story of Jesus' passion, one could compare stations 9–11, where the black is missing, with the scene of the transfiguration on the mount, here pulled into the one moment of the cry of why as a ray of light in the midst of the suffering itself. The last station could be seen, from the viewpoint of Christian iconography because of the broken white without black, as the resurrection. But is that not too triumphalistic and in conflict with Newman's intention to limit himself to the cry? One could point to Psalm 22 which Christ in fact cites. The psalm begins with the cry of forsakenness and ends in trust: "Rescue me from the mouth of the lions ... [He] has listened to his cry for help ... From you comes the theme of my praise in the great assembly." Newman himself seems to agree with this psalm that Jesus' cry is not a lament. He points further to the paradox that Jesus, as the persecuted on the cross, asks forgiveness for those who persecuted him and brought him to the cross.[62] This interpretation is in line with the last station without any black, only broken white. Jesus, through his forgiveness, is able to make a new beginning in the most desperate situation. That does not have to be seen directly as 'Christian.' The theme of a new beginning is repeated in Newman's work *Onement 1* (1948): his paintings and drawings are about genesis, about creating anew and about new beginnings.[63] The fourteenth station could point to this. In the catalogue Newman quotes the following from the Jewish work *Pirke Abot*:

> The ones who are born are to die
> Against thy will art thou formed
> Against thy will thou born
> Against thy will dost thou live
> Against thy will die.[64]

It is only that moment of the cry of the why that Newman wants to depict. Through this combination of the cry from the cross and the quotation from *Pirke Abot*, in *The Stations of the Cross* Newman takes the cry out of the context of the Christian faith. He gives new meaning to the suffering of Jesus: Jesus' cry as the cry of the human being regarding his finitude as such, the expression of the suffering of every person with the question of the why on his lips.

[50] Newman's new meaning for the cry can be clarified hermeneutically in the following way through the concept of exemplification. Exemplification points, as Goodman remarks, to the creative function of the work of art. The example for exemplification is the sample card. A sample of a material exemplifies the colour, material and structure of a certain material. A painting also exemplifies but does so metaphorically. The canvasses of *The Stations of the Cross* are literally black, grey and white but, metaphorically, sad with a flicker of hope. For Newman,

62. Newman, 'A Conversation: Barnett Newman and Thomas B. Hess,' in: BN, pp. 276f.

63. S. Polcari, *Abstract Expressionism and the Modern Experience* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991), pp. 188–95.

64. From Barnett Newman 'The Stations of the Cross: *Lema Sabachthani* (1966),' in: BN, p. 188.

art is not an illustration of something we already know. For that reason he does not call these paintings the '22nd Psalm' nor does he present, as stated, a depiction of the stations of the cross in the Catholic tradition. Or, to put it in terms of exemplification, instead of exemplifying recognized labels, these painting introduce new forms for organizing visual experience, and therefore they will function sooner as labels for experiences that we did not recognize as such in connection with suffering but will learn to know through these labels.[65] By referring to the *Pirke Abot* Newman broadens the specific character of Jesus' words on the cross about his suffering to the general issue of suffering as a consequence of the finitude of human existence. Jesus functions here, other than in Christian dogmatics, as an archetype. Jesus' suffering is the suffering of every human being. This is a possible explanation on the basis of the hints given by the author. What is decisive is whether *The Stations of the Cross* also evoke such an experience in the viewer.

4.3 Art and Theology

[51] *The Stations of the Cross* challenge the theologian. I will point to a few issues. As stated above, Newman gives another meaning to suffering than Christian theology does, i.e. the suffering of finitude—here in the context of the end of life through violence. Classical theology places all the emphasis in Christ's suffering on the relationship between God and human beings. Newman asks that we pay attention to another aspect in the gospels, namely that Christ, in his forsakenness by God, suffers as a human being in the face of his violent death. By consciously grouping the fourteen stations of the cross in Jesus' one cry of why, theology is confronted with the question of whether the suffering of Christ is not too easily seen an episode in the passion story and whether Good Friday does not change too quickly into Easter Sunday. Let us recall the words from the *Pirke Abot*: "The ones who are born are to die .... Against thy will die." By putting up for discussion the violent death of Jesus, caused by his persecutors, Newman touches on a theme on which the literary theorist René Girard has elaborated: the death of Jesus as scapegoat.

[52] Another question concerns the way in which *religious transcendence* is evoked here. Tillich's criterion of expressiveness is too much bound to the model of expressionism and does not suffice here because in this 'figureless' style of abstract expressionism, the breaking open of the surface is not an issue. Newman's work evokes transcendence in a different way. A correspondence with Romanticism has been indicated, with, for example, Caspar David Friedrich's paintings.[66] Or is it a type of negative theology? Newman's 'figureless style' evokes emptiness that, paradoxically, is full.[67] In station seven, for example, the

65. Goodman, *Languages of Art*, pp. 64f.

66. R. Rosenblum, 'The Abstract Sublime (1961),' in: *New York Painting and Sculpture*: 1940–1970, ed. H. Geldzahler (New York: E.P. Dutton & Co.), pp. 350–59.

67. M.C. Taylor, *Disfiguring: Art, Architecture, Religion* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 1992), p. 90 (with a reference to H. Rosenberg).



Figure 5: Barnett Newman, BE II, 1961–1964, Acryl und Öl auf Leinwand

black stripe is narrowed to a line and the black is moved to the right and is widened. One could speak of the divine opposite, suffering with the suffering of the creature.

[53] A third question of importance for theology is the interpretation of the *end*. Carel Blotkamp remarks that the completion of a work of art is a difficult process for the artist. Cézanne's work poses the question of when a painting is done.[68] In *The Stations of the Cross* the question of the end plays a role in this sense: Why does Newman hold to the fourteen stations, while not considering himself bound to the classical episodes of Christ's journey to the cross? The fourteenth station is, according to the tradition, Jesus' internment. In Newman's fourteenth

68. C. Blotkamp, *De onvoltooide van Cézanne. 40 korte beschouwingen over moderne kunst* (Warnsveld: Terra Lannoo, 2004), pp. 138–40; F. Baumann *et al.* (eds), *Vollendet Unvollendet Cézanne*, (Vienna: Hatje Cantz Verlag, 2000).

station, the black has disappeared and there is only broken white. The question here is what precisely *end* means. Does the white of the fourteenth station express human desire, the desire for a new world? In iconography white is, after all, the colour of purity, splendour, and victory? Newman himself, because of the horrors of the Second World War, no longer believes in a new world. He is not able to share Malevich's ideal of the new world.[69] This seems to lead to the rejection of another explanation of the end: the end as the opening for future possibilities. That would, however, be a shift from the cross to the resurrection, which is not Newman's intention. I do observe here a tension between the artist's intention and his work. At the same time as *The Stations of the Cross*, Newman painted *Be II* (1961–1964). This work is explained as Newman's answer to the cry.[70] The zip of orange-red, the only true colour on this canvas is seen as Newman's answer to the cry. Referring to the words from the *Pirke Abot*, one can say that *BE II* appeals – over against all suffering and finitude – to the ability of the human being to find meaning in the time fixed for him.[71] According to Newman, Jesus was an example of this. Let us recall what he said about Jesus' words of forgiveness on the cross. As a theologian, I would ask where the 'courage for meaning' is to be derived from. One cannot derive the courage for meaning in our finite existence from finitude itself. More than finitude is needed, as Newman obviously holds. That would explain why the experience of transcendence is so often evoked in his work.

[54] By means of Newman's *The Stations of the Cross* I wanted to show that a third position is possible regarding the relationship between art and religion: not exclusivism or of inclusivism but a true correlation between art and religion. Newman's art challenges theology with respect to suffering, transcendence and the end. There is interplay between art and religion regarding insights about human existence. Newman is undeniably influenced by Jewish and Christian sources. Theology discovers that artists also deal with the interpretation of existence and form insights about it. The Jesus of art is not the whole Jesus but is often the Jesus that theology has forgotten. Theological aesthetics is supposed to fill this lacuna. If Christian theology does not learn anything from art, it may well become esoteric and, conversely, a culture may well become superficial if it does not make use of the sources of the Christian religion or of other religions. The enrichment that mutual interplay between art and religion brings is different for the different genres—literature, film, drama, architecture, sculpture, music. That requires further specification.

5 In Conclusion

[55] This example shows that the practice of the discipline of theological aesthetics is an activity on the border between several disciplines. That entails the danger that that which is situated on the border is exposed to critique from both

69. Newman, 'A Conversation: Barnett Newman and Thomas B. Hess,' in: BN, p. 275.
70. For this and what follows immediately see Meyer, *The Stations of the Cross*, p. 140.
71. Meyer, *The Stations of the Cross*, p. 142.

sides. Standing on the border between theology, philosophy and reflection on art is vulnerable for the traveller at the border who comes from other disciplines. Tillich, however, calls the border the fruitful place of knowledge.[72] Thinking on the border is fruitful because in theological aesthetics the horizons of different disciplines must be fused.[73]

72. Tillich, 'Auf der Grenze (1962),' in: *Gesammelte Werke*, parts 12, 13.

73. This article is a reworking of the published version of my inaugural lecture on the occasion of my acceptance of the chair of Professor of Aesthetics from the Vrije Universiteitsfonds on October 5, 2006. This chair is an interdisciplinary chair for the faculties of philosophy, theology and letters of VU University Amsterdam, The Netherlands.